pathogens is a novelty. Influenza A, for example, is a familiar strain of the virus that is a leading cause of seasonal flu epidemics in the world. Mycoplasma pneumoniae is a bacteria that causes "walking pneumonia", a milder form of pneumonia. The virus that presently seems to be spreading the fastest in China—Human metapneumovirus (hMPV)—is also a common winter infection that has been around since at least 2001.

But though the cause of the current spike in China remains as yet undetermined, the experts' concerns stem from the fact that all the reported symptoms are flu-like—cold, fever, fatigue and bodyache—making them wonder if the world could be looking at an altogether new virus, or a new, more infectious strain of an old one. Those concerns took root in India as well as it reported its first cases of hMPV—two in Bengaluru, in a three-month-old girl and an eight-month-old boy, and one in Ahmedabad, in a two-month-old child.

Like its other cousins in the *Pneumoviridae* family of viruses, hMPV, too, affects the human lungs and airways, particularly in children under 14. It was first isolated in the Netherlands. There is no medication or vaccine for it as yet, only simple rest and symptomatic treatment. It can become a risk factor in very young children, the elderly and the immunocompromised.

"The infection is more common among neonates (infants less than four weeks old) and infants (children aged under one). It has also been reported in large numbers among elderly people," says Dr Raja Dhar, head of the department of pulmonology at CMRI Hospital, Kolkata. Ominously, his practice suggests to him "a significantly large" spread of hMPV in India. "As an adult pulmonologist, two out of 10 patients who visit me have traits of metapneumovirus. It is crucial to note that infections caused due to metapneumovirus coupled with other bacterial infections can lead to serious respiratory conditions," he says. Asked whether the world could be staring at a pandemic-like situation as with Covid-19, the doctor says we should always stay prepared to combat any infection that is spreading on a mass scale.

A NEW THREAT CALLED HMPV



AP

COUNTERING A SPIKE Patients get immunotherapy at a Shanghai hospital, Dec. 27, 2024

- **Belongs to a family of viruses called *Pneumoviridae***
- **Was first isolated in the Netherlands in 2001**
- **Affects the respiratory tract and manifests in flu-like symptoms**
- **Usually afflicts young children under 14 years of age**
- **Has no medication for cure or vaccine for prevention. Treatment is aymptomatic, along with rest**
- **China is seeing a surge in cases since December. India has reported first few cases in three infants**

IS A NEW MUTANT IN PLAY OR AN ENTIRELY NEW VIRUS? INDIA HAS REPORTED NO SURGE, BUT CLINICAL EVIDENCE ALREADY SUGGESTS A WIDE PRESENCE OF HMPV

As a precautionary measure, the Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW) convened a Joint Monitoring Group (JMG) meeting in the first week of January under the chairmanship of the Directorate General of Health Services to discuss the situation. "These viruses are already in circulation globally, including in India. A robust surveillance system for Influenza Like Illness (ILI) and Severe Acute Respiratory Illness (SARI) for Influenza is already in place in India and the data from both indicate no unusual surge in ILI and SARI cases. Physicians from hospitals also confirmed that there is no surge in respiratory illness cases in